

Crisis Policing in Toronto’s Neighbourhoods*

Mental Health Act apprehensions are more frequent where more households rent
and more Indigenous people live, 2014–2025

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Toronto police detained people under Ontario’s *Mental Health Act* about 11,000 times a year between 2014 and 2025, four times in five on an officer’s own judgement. We link these 131,325 apprehensions to 2021 Census profiles of the city’s 158 neighbourhoods. Apprehension rates are about 16 per cent higher for each standard-deviation increase in the share of households that rent, and about 21 per cent higher for each standard-deviation increase in the share of Indigenous residents, and both associations hold outside the downtown core. Race-based data on 65,276 arrests in 2020–2021 show that Black and Indigenous people were arrested at about three times the White rate, and that people police flagged as mentally unstable were strip searched far more often, especially if they were Black. These results point to the neighbourhoods where Toronto’s new non-police crisis service could reach the most people.

Keywords: Mental Health Act; police apprehension; crisis response; neighbourhoods; race-based data; Toronto

1 Introduction

When someone in Toronto is in a mental health crisis, the people who arrive are usually police officers. Ontario’s *Mental Health Act* lets an officer detain a person and take them to hospital for a psychiatric assessment, a power known as an apprehension (Government of Ontario 1990). In Canada about one in three people with a mental or substance use disorder had contact with police in a year (Boyce et al. 2015), and internationally about one in ten people with a mental disorder had police involved in their pathway to care (Livingston 2016). Some of these encounters in Toronto have been fatal, which led to an independent review of how police

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respond to people in crisis (Iacobucci 2014) and, in 2022, to the Toronto Community Crisis Service, which sends mental health workers instead of police to some calls (Provincial System Support Program and Shkaabe Makwa 2023).

We ask where in Toronto crisis policing is concentrated and who it falls on. We use 131,325 Mental Health Act apprehensions recorded by the Toronto Police Service from 2014 to 2025 (Toronto Police Service 2026a), about 10,900 a year, and link them to 2021 Census characteristics of the city’s 158 neighbourhoods (City of Toronto 2026a, 2026b). The estimand is the association between a neighbourhood’s characteristics and its apprehension rate per resident, holding the other characteristics and the year constant. The apprehension data does not record race, so we also use the Toronto Police Service’s race-based data on 65,276 arrests in 2020 and 2021 (Toronto Police Service 2026b), which records the race police perceived for each person and whether they appeared to be in a mental health crisis.

Apprehension rates are higher where more households rent and where more Indigenous people live: about 16 per cent higher for a one-standard-deviation increase in renter share, and about 21 per cent higher for the same increase in Indigenous share. Both associations hold when we drop the downtown core, where many of the people apprehended do not live. Low income matters only through the downtown core, and Black population share and the City’s designation of disadvantaged neighbourhoods add little. In the arrest data, Black and Indigenous people were arrested at about 3.1 and 2.8 times the White rate relative to their share of the population, and an officer’s mental-instability flag raised the chance of a strip search most for Black people.

Studies elsewhere have found coercive psychiatric care concentrated in deprived and racialized areas (Weich et al. 2017) and among Black patients (Anderson et al. 2014), but Toronto’s police data has not been examined this way at the neighbourhood level. The results also suggest where non-police crisis response would reach the most people. Section 2 describes the data, Section 3 the models and Section 4 the results, and Section 5 discusses them along with the paper’s limitations.

2 Data

2.1 Sources

We use four datasets, downloaded and processed in Python (Python Software Foundation 2025) with polars (Vink et al. 2026), pandas (McKinney 2010), NumPy (Harris et al. 2020), GeoPandas (Jordahl et al. 2026) and Shapely (Gillies et al. 2025). Figures are made with plotnine (Kibirige et al. 2026), tables with Great Tables (Iannone and Chow 2026), models are fitted with statsmodels (Seabold and Perktold 2010), data tests use pytest (Krekel et al. 2026), and the paper is written in Quarto (Allaire et al. 2026). The workflow follows Alexander (2023).

1. **Mental Health Act Apprehensions** (Toronto Police Service 2026a), from Open Data Toronto (City of Toronto 2026c): one row per apprehension from 2014, with the date, legal authority, sex, age group, type of place and neighbourhood.
2. **Neighbourhoods** (City of Toronto 2026b) and **Neighbourhood Profiles** (City of Toronto 2026a): boundaries of the City’s 158 social-planning neighbourhoods and their 2021 Census counts, from which we take population, household tenure, low income, visible minority and Indigenous identity, along with the City’s 2020 neighbourhood designation (City of Toronto 2014).
3. **Race and Identity Based Data Collection: Arrests and Strip Searches** (Toronto Police Service 2026b): one row per person arrested or strip searched in 2020 and 2021, with the race the officer perceived, demographics, offence category, behaviour recorded at arrest, and whether the person was booked and strip searched. The Open Data Toronto copy stops at 32,000 rows, so we take all 65,276 from the Toronto Police Service’s own source.

2.2 Measurement

An apprehension usually starts with a 9-1-1 call from a family member, a bystander or the person in crisis. If the officer who attends believes the person is acting in a disorderly way and is likely to seriously harm themselves or someone else, or cannot care for themselves, the officer can detain them under Section 17 of the *Mental Health Act* and take them to hospital (Government of Ontario 1990). Police also carry out apprehensions authorized by others: a physician’s application (Section 15), a justice of the peace’s order (Section 16), a community treatment order (Section 33.4), or a hospital seeking the return of an absent patient (Section 28). Each apprehension is logged in the police records system with the neighbourhood where it happened, and the published data is extracted from that system.

Each row is an apprehension, so a person detained five times appears five times, and there is no person identifier. The location is where the apprehension happened, which need not be where the person lives. Records of people aged 17 and under are removed before publication. Neighbourhood is missing for 1,438 apprehensions, which we count in citywide totals only. Crisis calls resolved on scene, calls diverted to the Community Crisis Service and voluntary visits to hospital never appear. An apprehension is therefore one possible outcome of a police encounter and a poor measure of mental health need.

Neighbourhood characteristics come from the 2021 Census long-form questionnaire, a 25 per cent sample, which we treat as fixed across the twelve years. In the arrest data, race is the officer’s perception at the time of arrest, and behaviour flags such as “mental instability or possibly suicidal” are also officers’ judgements. For a population benchmark we grouped 2021 Census categories to match the police ones. East and Southeast Asian, for example, combines Chinese, Filipino, Southeast Asian, Korean and Japanese, and White is approximated by residents who are neither a visible minority nor Indigenous.

2.3 Apprehensions over time and place

Apprehensions rose by about 81 per cent from 7,387 in 2014 to a peak of 13,350 in 2021, dipped after the Community Crisis Service began in March 2022, and have since returned to about 12,700 a year (Figure 1). Women account for 44 per cent of apprehensions, and the most common age group is 25 to 34. Of all apprehensions, 79 per cent rest on an officer’s own judgement under Section 17, up from 78 per cent in 2014 to 82 per cent in 2025 (Table 3 in Section A). In four cases out of five, no physician or court was involved before police detained the person.

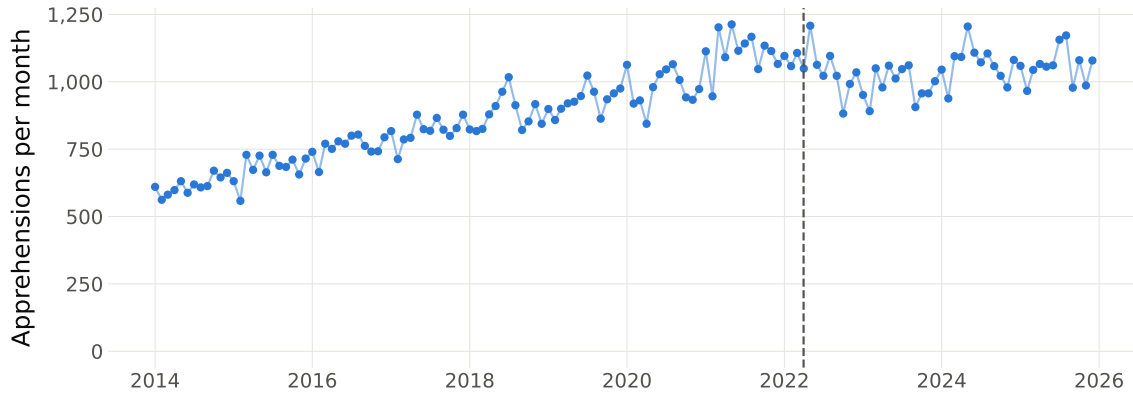


Figure 1: Mental Health Act apprehensions in Toronto rose through 2021 and have been roughly flat since. Each point is one month’s total; the dashed line marks the launch of the Toronto Community Crisis Service pilots in March 2022.

To compare neighbourhoods of different sizes we use rates: the average number of apprehensions per year per 1,000 residents. The median neighbourhood has 3.5, and rates run from 1.2 in Steeles to 17.1 in University. The highest rates are in the downtown core, with further pockets in the northwest and east (Figure 2). Downtown rates are inflated because apprehensions are counted where they happen but divided by the people who live there. Downtown neighbourhoods hold hospitals, shelters, transit hubs and large daytime populations, while University has only 6,435 residents. Residential population is a poor denominator for such places (Andresen 2011), so we define a downtown core of 13 neighbourhoods, those whose centre lies east of Bathurst Street, west of the Don River and south of Bloor Street, and repeat every analysis without them.

2.4 Neighbourhood characteristics

Table 1 summarizes the characteristics used in the model. The share of households that rent ranges from under 10 per cent to almost 90 per cent, and the Indigenous share of residents, small

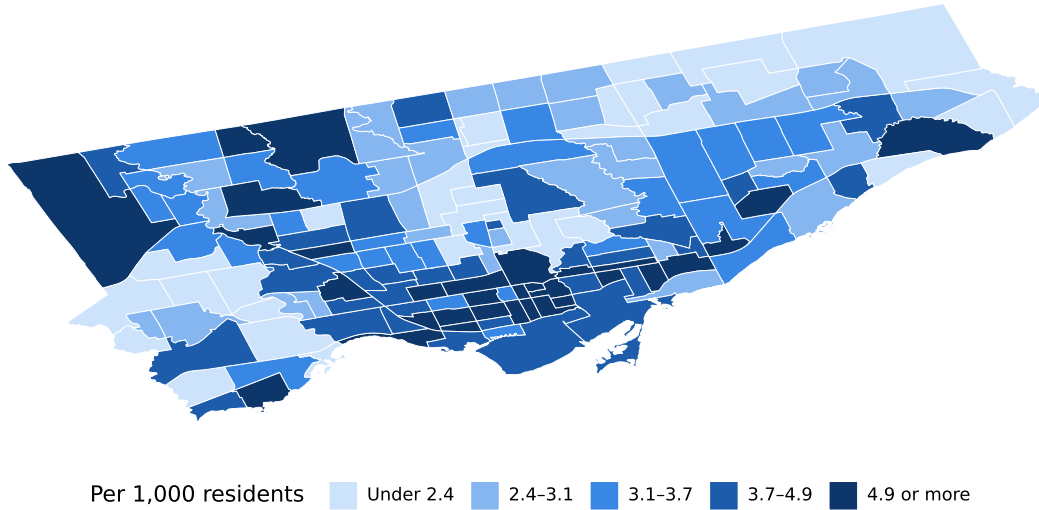


Figure 2: Apprehension rates are highest in the downtown core, with further high-rate areas in the northwest and east. Each of the 158 neighbourhoods is shaded by its average annual apprehensions per 1,000 residents in 2014–2025, grouped into fifths.

Table 1: Toronto’s 158 neighbourhoods differ widely in renting, income and population composition. Values are the median and range across neighbourhoods, from the 2021 Census, alongside the average annual apprehension rate for 2014–2025.

Measure	Median	Range
Apprehensions per 1,000 residents per year	3.5	1.2 – 17.1
Population	16,812	6,260 – 33,300
Households that rent (%)	46	8 – 89
Residents in low income (%)	12.2	4.3 – 29.0
Indigenous residents (%)	0.8	0.0 – 3.0
Black residents (%)	6.8	0.7 – 37.9
Visible minority residents (%)	51	13 – 96
Median household income (\$)	84,500	57,200 – 222,000

everywhere, varies more than seventy-fold. 33 neighbourhoods are designated Neighbourhood Improvement Areas, the City’s label for neighbourhoods below its equity benchmark (City of Toronto 2014).

Figure 3 plots each neighbourhood’s apprehension rate against the four shares in the model. Rates rise with renter, low-income and Indigenous share, and only slightly with Black share. Downtown neighbourhoods, in orange, sit at the top of each panel. Without them the renter and Indigenous associations remain and the low-income one is much weaker. The shares are correlated with one another, so the model in Section 3 estimates them together.



Figure 3: Apprehension rates rise with the share of households that rent and the share of Indigenous residents. Each point is one neighbourhood; orange points are the downtown core. The vertical axis is on a log scale, and grey lines are least-squares fits on that scale.

2.5 Arrests and strip searches by race

The arrest data contains 65,276 records for 37,347 people. Counting the different people arrested at least once in 2020 and 2021 per 1,000 residents of the same perceived-race group, Black people were arrested at 38.6, Indigenous people at 35.6 and White people at 12.5 (Figure 4). This is in line with earlier evidence of disproportionate police contact with Black Torontonians (Wortley and Owusu-Bempah 2011; Meng 2017; Ontario Human Rights Commission 2020). The ratios are approximate, because the people arrested include non-residents while the benchmark counts residents only.

Toronto police strip searched 27 per cent of the people they arrested from January to September 2020. Strip searches are lawful only when the circumstances of an arrest give specific grounds for one (Supreme Court of Canada 2001), and a provincial review had found Toronto’s rate far above other Ontario services (Office of the Independent Police Review Director 2019). After a new procedure took effect in October 2020, the rate fell to 1 per cent by the last quarter of 2021. Before the change, more than half of booked Indigenous, Black and White people were strip searched, against about a third of other groups (Section D). Officers flagged 3.3 per cent of arrests for “mental instability or possibly suicidal” behaviour, and this flag is the arrest data’s link to crisis policing.

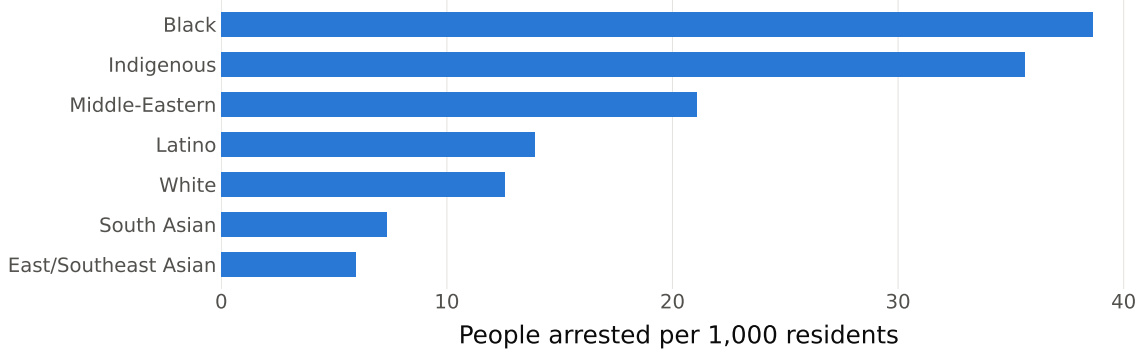


Figure 4: Black and Indigenous people were arrested at about three times the White rate in 2020–2021, relative to their share of Toronto’s population. Bars show the number of different people arrested at least once per 1,000 residents of the same perceived-race group.

2.6 Ethics

Both datasets record people at difficult moments, some of them more than once. The published data has no names, exact locations or dates of birth, apprehension records of young people are withheld, and arrest records give only quarters and police divisions. We report only aggregates. Race in the arrest data is the officer’s perception and may differ from how the person identifies. The apprehension analysis describes neighbourhoods: a higher rate where more Indigenous people live does not show that Indigenous residents are apprehended more, and we do not claim that it does.

3 Model

3.1 Apprehension rates

We model the number of apprehensions y_{it} in neighbourhood i in year t as negative binomial, with the neighbourhood’s population N_i as exposure (Equation 1):

$$\begin{aligned}
 y_{it} &\sim \text{NegativeBinomial}(\mu_{it}, \alpha) \\
 \log \mu_{it} &= \log N_i + \beta_0 + \beta_1 \text{Renter}_i + \beta_2 \text{LowIncome}_i + \beta_3 \text{Indigenous}_i \\
 &\quad + \beta_4 \text{Black}_i + \beta_5 \text{NIA}_i + \gamma_t
 \end{aligned} \tag{1}$$

where the four shares are standardized to mean zero and standard deviation one across neighbourhoods, NIA indicates a Neighbourhood Improvement Area, and γ_t are year effects. Each $\exp(\beta_k)$ is a rate ratio: the multiplicative change in the apprehension rate for a one-standard-deviation increase in that characteristic, with the others and the year held fixed.

The counts are far more variable than a Poisson model allows (the neighbourhood-year mean is 69 and the variance 2,582), so we use the negative binomial, whose dispersion parameter α is estimated at 0.15. Year effects absorb citywide changes such as the 2021 peak and the launch of the Community Crisis Service, so the β_k compare neighbourhoods within the same year. Each neighbourhood appears twelve times, so standard errors are clustered by neighbourhood. We leave out median household income, which is correlated with low-income share ($r = -0.70$); variance inflation factors stay near 2 without it and below 2.5 with it. The model is fitted with statsmodels (Seabold and Perktold 2010) on 1,896 neighbourhood-years. Fitted to simulated data with known effects, it recovers them (Section B).

We fit four versions: all apprehensions, apprehensions outside the 13 downtown neighbourhoods, Section 17 apprehensions only, and the other authorities only. If officers' discretion is shaped by the character of places (Morabito 2007), Section 17 apprehensions should track neighbourhood characteristics more closely than those decided by a physician or a court.

3.2 Strip searches

For the arrest data we fit a logistic regression of whether a booked person was strip searched, using arrests from January to September 2020, before the procedure change (Equation 2):

$$\text{logit } \Pr(\text{Strip}_j = 1) = \delta_0 + \delta_1 \text{Flag}_j + \sum_g \theta_g \text{Race}_{jg} + \sum_g \lambda_g (\text{Flag}_j \times \text{Race}_{jg}) + \mathbf{x}'_j \boldsymbol{\eta} \quad (2)$$

where Flag_j indicates that the officer recorded mental instability, race groups are Black, Indigenous and other groups (East and Southeast Asian, South Asian, Middle-Eastern and Latino combined) with White as the reference, and $\mathbf{x}_j$ holds offence category, age group and sex. The interaction terms λ_g test whether the flag's association with strip searching differs by group. Standard errors are clustered by person because some people were arrested several times.

4 Results

4.1 Neighbourhood characteristics and apprehension rates

Table 2 reports the rate ratios, and Figure 6 in Section B plots them. Across all neighbourhoods, the rate ratio for a one-standard-deviation increase is 1.16 (95% CI 1.05–1.28) for renter share and 1.21 (95% CI 1.13–1.28) for Indigenous share. Low-income share has a smaller association, 1.12 (95% CI 1.01–1.25). Black share, 1.02 (95% CI 0.95–1.10), and Improvement Area status, 0.93 (95% CI 0.77–1.13), are not distinguishable from no association.

Table 2: Renter share and Indigenous share are associated with higher apprehension rates in every specification. Rate ratios per one-standard-deviation increase (per 1 for Improvement Area status), with 95% confidence intervals, from negative binomial models with population exposure, year effects and standard errors clustered by neighbourhood.

	All	Excl. downtown	Section 17	Other types
Households that rent	1.16 (1.05–1.28)	1.17 (1.08–1.26)	1.16 (1.07–1.26)	1.14 (0.94–1.38)
Residents in low income	1.12 (1.01–1.25)	0.99 (0.91–1.07)	1.09 (0.99–1.20)	1.23 (1.03–1.47)
Indigenous residents	1.21 (1.13–1.28)	1.17 (1.12–1.23)	1.18 (1.12–1.24)	1.33 (1.17–1.52)
Black residents	1.02 (0.95–1.10)	1.03 (0.97–1.11)	1.03 (0.96–1.10)	1.03 (0.89–1.18)
Improvement Area	0.93 (0.77–1.13)	1.09 (0.93–1.28)	0.95 (0.80–1.14)	0.82 (0.59–1.14)
Neighbourhood-years	1,896	1,740	1,896	1,896
Dispersion (alpha)	0.15	0.12	0.12	0.51

Without the downtown core, the renter and Indigenous associations barely change, at 1.17 and 1.17, but the low-income association disappears, at 0.99 (95% CI 0.91–1.07). The link between poverty and apprehensions in the full model comes from the downtown core, where residential rates are least reliable. Section 17 apprehensions follow almost the same pattern as all apprehensions, so officer-initiated apprehensions are no more closely tied to neighbourhood characteristics than the rest. The other authorities track low income (1.23) and Indigenous share (1.33) somewhat more strongly, with wider intervals.

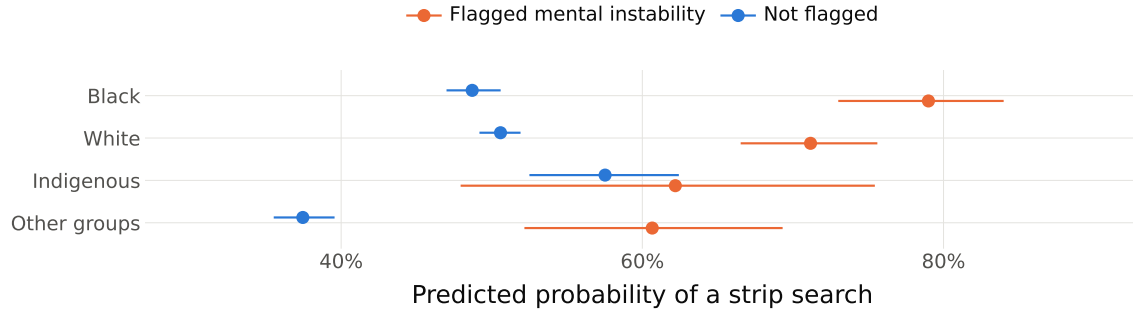


Figure 5: A mental-instability flag raised the predicted probability of a strip search for every group, most of all for Black people. Booked arrests, January–September 2020, adjusted for offence, age and sex; lines are 95% intervals.

4.2 Mental health flags and strip searches

Among booked arrests before the procedure change, a mental-instability flag is associated with much higher odds of a strip search for White people, with an odds ratio of 2.74 (95% CI 2.11–3.56) after adjusting for offence, age and sex. The association is larger for Black people,

with an interaction odds ratio of 1.75 (95% CI 1.11–2.74). In predicted probabilities (Figure 5), booked Black and White people without a flag were about equally likely to be strip searched, at 49 per cent and 51 per cent. With a flag, the probability rose to 71 per cent for White people and 79 per cent for Black people. The Indigenous estimate rests on 29 flagged arrests and is too uncertain to interpret. Full estimates are in Section C.

5 Discussion

5.1 Crisis policing follows renting and Indigenous presence

Apprehensions are more frequent where more households rent and more Indigenous people live, both inside and outside the downtown core. Renting probably stands in for things the census does not measure directly, such as residential instability, rooming houses and supportive housing, and fewer private resources for managing a crisis without calling 9-1-1. This reading fits Toronto research showing that homeless people with mental illness have more police contact than those who are housed (Kouyoumdjian et al. 2019), and English research showing that compulsory psychiatric admission is more likely in deprived and more ethnically diverse small areas (Weich et al. 2017). The association with Indigenous share matches the over-representation of Indigenous people in police contact generally, although neighbourhood data cannot tell us whether Indigenous residents themselves are apprehended more.

Neighbourhood poverty mattered only through the downtown core, and the Improvement Area designation added nothing once renting and Indigenous share were in the model, so crisis policing appears tied to particular features of neighbourhoods more than to disadvantage in general. Black population share also had little association with apprehension rates. This does not conflict with research showing that Black people are more likely to reach psychiatric care through police (Anderson et al. 2014): three of the five lowest-rate neighbourhoods are over 90 per cent visible minority, and a neighbourhood’s makeup says little about who in it is detained.

5.2 Officer discretion is not more place-bound

We expected officer-initiated apprehensions to track neighbourhood characteristics more closely than those authorized by physicians or courts, and they did not. Officers can only apprehend people they are called to, so the decision to call may matter more than the officer’s judgement on scene, and calls depend on who is present, who is watching and who has other options. Apprehensions under the other authorities often involve people already known to mental health services, who may live near supportive housing and treatment programs.

5.3 Race and crisis at arrest

The largest racial disparity in the arrest data is in who is arrested at all. The Ontario Human Rights Commission found a similar pattern in 2013–2017, when Black people were charged at 3.9 times the White rate (Ontario Human Rights Commission 2020). Once booked, Black and White people were strip searched at almost the same rate, and searches found items at similar rates for every group (Section D), which is consistent with equal search standards but does not prove them (Knowles et al. 2001; Simoiu et al. 2017). People in apparent crisis were treated differently: a mental-instability flag made a strip search far more likely, especially for Black people. In Victoria, Australia, police were more likely to use or threaten weapons against people who appeared mentally ill (Kesic et al. 2013); here, apparent crisis was linked to the most intrusive search police conduct.

5.4 Weaknesses and next steps

The analysis is ecological, so its associations describe neighbourhoods and cannot be applied to individuals. The residential denominator distorts downtown rates, and high-traffic places outside downtown, such as the area around the Centre for Addiction and Mental Health in West Queen West, are affected too; an ambient-population denominator would be better (Andresen 2011). Census characteristics are fixed at 2021 while apprehensions span twelve years, and without a person identifier a few people detained repeatedly may weigh heavily in some neighbourhoods. The arrest data covers only 2020 and 2021, years shaped by the pandemic, relies on officers’ perceptions of race and behaviour, and has few flagged people in some groups.

Year effects absorb the 2022 dip, so our models cannot say whether the Community Crisis Service reduced apprehensions. The service received about 4,500 eligible 9-1-1 calls in 2025, against roughly 12,700 apprehensions (City of Toronto 2026d). Because its pilots began in specific areas, comparing pilot and other neighbourhoods before and after 2022, as was done for Denver’s similar program (Dee and Pyne 2022), could estimate its effect. Linking apprehensions to health records, as Ontario studies of involuntary admission have done (Lebenbaum et al. 2018), would show who is detained and what happens next. Apprehension data that recorded the person’s race, which Toronto already publishes for arrests, would allow the individual-level analysis that neighbourhood data cannot support.

Declarations

Data and code availability. All data are public: the apprehension, neighbourhood and census data from Open Data Toronto under the Open Government Licence – Toronto, and the arrest data from the Toronto Police Service. Code, cleaned data, a snapshot of the raw data

and the fitted models are at <https://github.com/TheZarif/toronto-crisis-policing> under the MIT License.

Use of generative AI. Claude (Anthropic) assisted with analysis code, documentation, the literature search and revision of the text. The author checked every citation against its source and every result against the code, and takes responsibility for the content.

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A Data cleaning and apprehension types

- **Period.** We keep apprehensions that occurred from 2014 to the last complete calendar year, 2025, dropping 13 records with earlier occurrence dates and the partial current year.
- **Missing codes.** “NSA” and “Not Recorded” values are treated as missing.
- **Repeated incidents.** Some incidents involve more than one person and share an incident number. All rows are kept because each is a separate apprehension, and there is no person identifier with which to identify duplicates.
- **Neighbourhood panel.** Every neighbourhood-year appears, with zeros where there were no apprehensions.
- **Downtown core.** Neighbourhoods whose centroid lies east of Bathurst Street (longitude -79.4065), west of the Don River (-79.356) and south of Bloor Street (latitude 43.6705), approximating the City’s Downtown Plan area.
- **Arrest data.** Labels that changed between 2020 and 2021 (offence categories, age groups, youth status) are combined into one scheme. Strip searches without a recorded booking are treated as booked, following the source documentation. Our cleaned data reproduces the Toronto Police Service’s published strip search rate of 22.2 per cent for 2020 (Toronto Police Service 2022).
- **Tests.** Automated tests check every cleaned and simulated table for schema, valid values, internal consistency and agreement with the raw data.

Table 3 counts apprehensions by the legal authority used.

Table 3: Four in five apprehensions in 2014–2025 were made under Section 17, on the officer’s own judgement. The other authorities carry out a decision by a physician, a justice of the peace or a hospital.

Authority	Who decides	Apprehensions	Share
Section 17	Police officer, on scene	104,164	79.3%
Section 15 (Form 1)	Physician	10,703	8.2%
Section 16 (Form 2)	Justice of the peace	9,074	6.9%
Section 33.4 (Form 47)	Physician, community treatment order	5,777	4.4%
Section 28 (Form 9)	Hospital, patient absent without leave	1,607	1.2%

B Model checks

B.1 Stability across specifications

Figure 6 plots the rate ratios from Table 2 for all four specifications.

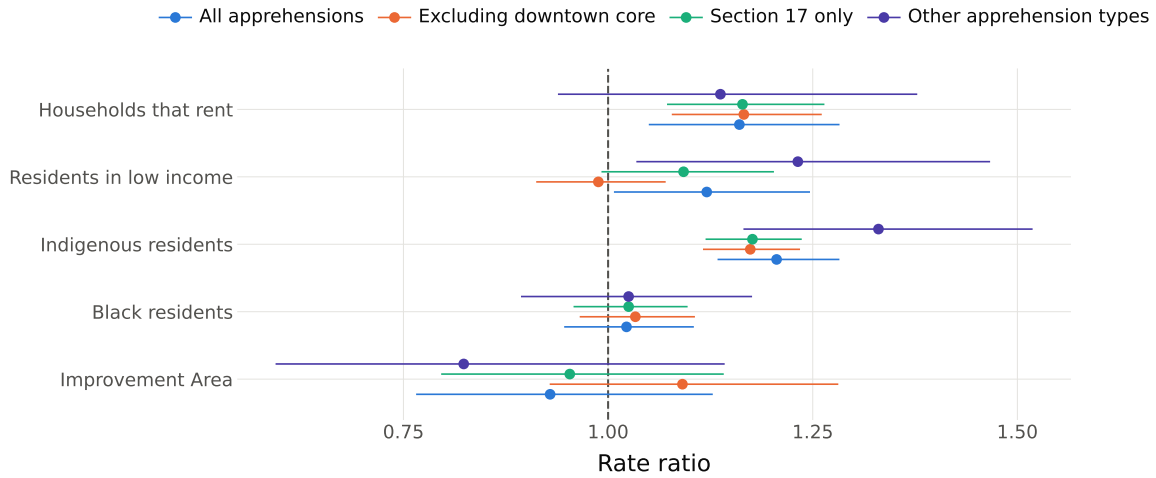


Figure 6: The associations with renter share and Indigenous share hold across specifications, while the low-income association disappears without the downtown core. Points are rate ratios and lines are 95% confidence intervals; values above 1 mean higher apprehension rates.

B.2 Recovery of simulated effects

We simulated neighbourhood-year counts in which the log apprehension rate rises by 0.015 per percentage point of renter households and falls by 0.6 per unit of log median income, with overdispersion $\alpha = 0.2$. Fitting the same model specification to the simulated data recovers these values (Table 4).

Table 4: The negative binomial specification recovers the effects built into the simulated data. True values are those used to simulate; estimates and 95% confidence intervals are from fitting the model to the simulation.

Parameter	True value	Estimate	95% CI
Renter share (per point)	0.015	0.015	0.014 to 0.017
Log median income	-0.600	-0.552	-0.62 to -0.48
Dispersion (alpha)	0.200	0.188	

B.3 Fit to observed counts

Figure 7 compares the main model's fitted counts with the observed counts for every neighbourhood-year. Points lie close to the diagonal across the range, with the largest residuals in a few downtown neighbourhoods.

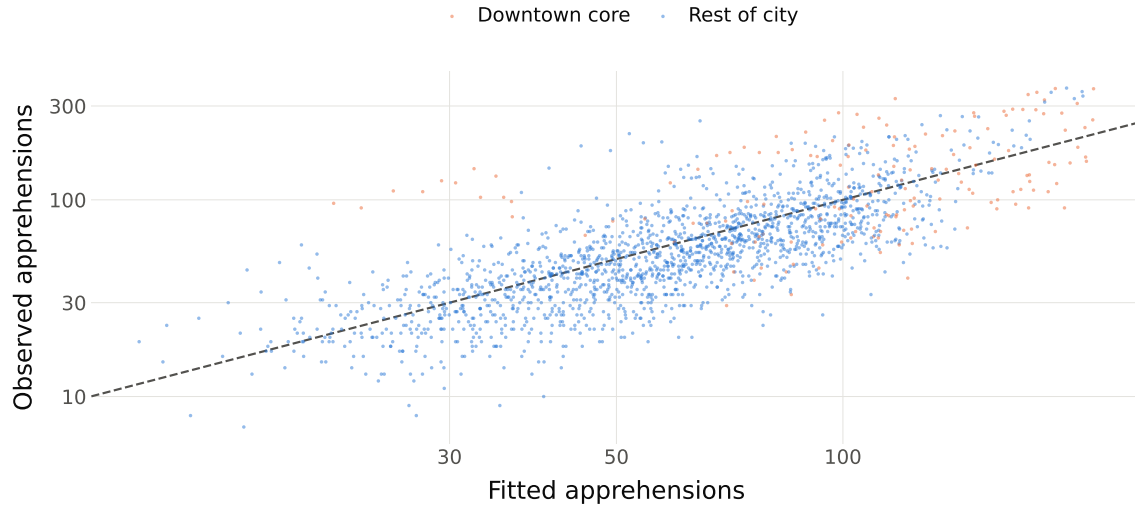


Figure 7: The main model’s fitted counts track the observed counts across all 1,896 neighbourhood-years. Each point is one neighbourhood in one year; orange points are the downtown core; the dashed line marks perfect agreement. Both axes are on a log scale.

C Strip search model

Table 5: A mental-instability flag nearly triples the odds of a strip search, and the increase is larger for Black people. Odds ratios with 95% confidence intervals from a logistic regression of strip searching among booked arrests in January–September 2020, adjusted for offence category, age group and sex, with standard errors clustered by person. White people are the reference group.

Term	Odds ratio	95% CI low	95% CI high	p-value
Black	0.92	0.82	1.02	0.110
Indigenous	1.38	1.09	1.76	0.008
Other groups	0.53	0.47	0.60	0.000
Mental-instability flag	2.74	2.11	3.56	0.000
Flag × Black	1.75	1.11	2.74	0.015
Flag × Indigenous	0.46	0.20	1.02	0.056
Flag × Other groups	1.10	0.67	1.80	0.706

D Disparities at each stage of contact

Figure 8 shows strip search rates among booked arrests before and after the October 2020 procedure change. Table 6 follows each perceived-race group from the population through

arrest, booking and strip search before the change, and reports how often strip searches found items. The largest departure from population shares is at arrest. Booking and strip search rates for Black and White people are similar, and the share of strip searches that found items is similar for every group.

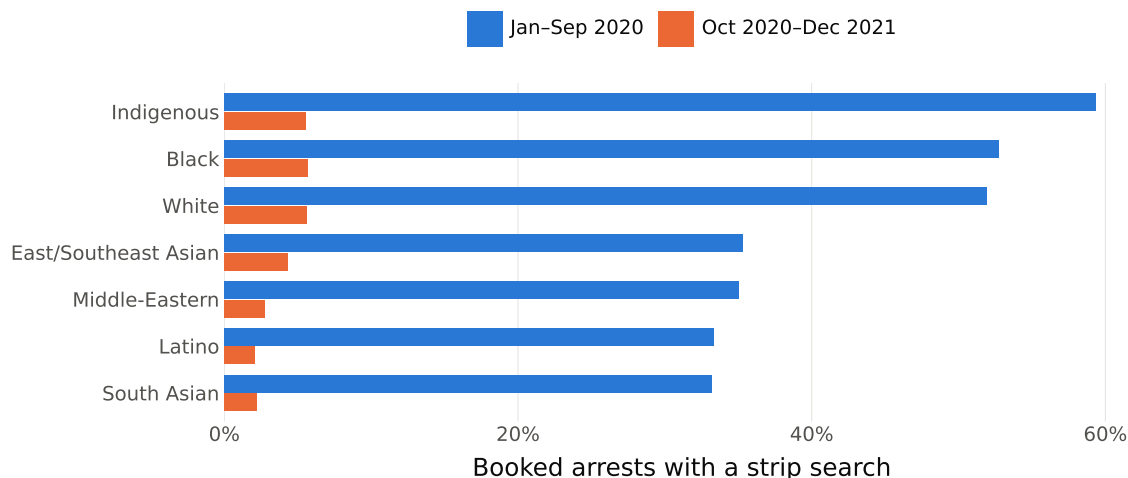


Figure 8: Before the October 2020 procedure change, more than half of booked Indigenous, Black and White people were strip searched; afterwards rates fell below 6 per cent for every group. Bars show the share of booked arrests that included a strip search.

Table 6: The largest racial disparity is at arrest; booking, strip search and search outcomes differ much less between Black and White people. Population share is from the 2021 Census; arrest share counts different people arrested in 2020–2021; booking and strip search rates are for January–September 2020; items found is the share of all strip searches in 2020–2021 that found items.

Perceived race	Population	People arrested	Booked	Strip searched	Items found
White	45%	42%	56%	52%	38%
East/Southeast Asian	22%	10%	52%	35%	34%
South Asian	15%	8%	54%	33%	35%
Black	10%	28%	59%	53%	38%
Middle-Eastern	4%	7%	50%	35%	37%
Latino	3%	4%	60%	33%	36%
Indigenous	1%	2%	61%	59%	38%